

Indian SATCOM: Reliance vs Airtel vs Starlink

In India, significant developments are underway in satellite communication (SATCOM) involving Reliance Jio, Bharti Airtel, and SpaceX's Starlink.

Reliance Jio, in partnership with Luxembourg-based SES, is close to rolling out its SATCOM services by the end of 2025. The Jio-SES joint venture has already prepared ground infrastructure, including a gateway in Kadapa, Andhra Pradesh, and plans to add more gateways. This service will integrate with Jio's 5G network, primarily using SES's O3b mPOWER medium Earth orbit satellites, which were recently boosted by new satellite launches to increase capacity threefold by 2026. Jio will work with Starlink to serve consumer users while relying on SES satellites for core 5G backhaul services. The price gap between fiber and SATCOM services has narrowed significantly, with Jio aiming to maintain cost leadership in this space.

Bharti Airtel has signed a strategic agreement with SpaceX to bring Starlink's high-speed internet to Indian customers, complementing its existing

satellite partnerships like Eutelsat OneWeb. Airtel plans to offer Starlink services via its retail network and business channels and is focusing on connecting rural and underserved areas. Airtel awaits spectrum allocation to launch fully and has prepared ground stations in Gujarat and Tamil Nadu. Airtel advocates for an auction-based, level playing field for satellite spectrum similar to terrestrial telecoms.

Starlink, owned by SpaceX, received regulatory approval from India's space authority (IN-SPACe) and the Department of Telecommunications to operate satellite broadband in India. The commercial launch is expected by late 2025 or early 2026, offering internet via a low-Earth orbit satellite constellation. Starlink will use Ka and Ku band frequencies for service delivery and has partnered with both Jio and Airtel for distribution and infrastructure support.

Together, these players signal the imminent arrival of commercial SATCOM broadband services in India, aimed at bridging connectivity gaps in remote and rural locations using advanced satellite networks.

Scindia also connected the need of satcom adoption to India's broader telecom journey and need of competition. "We have today given out three LIC-ES: one for Jio, one for OneWeb, and now one for Starlink," he stated.

"It's my job as telecom minister to make sure that we introduce every technology in our country, thereby giving choice to our customers and second, ensure that we promote a competitive environment, such that the customer always has a choice. And that's the mission behind which we've taken all those actions," he added.

Starlink's India launch is much anticipated as it is expected to boost connectivity across rural India through satellite technology and boost digital accessibility.

Overall, what was great to see that India's telecom journey is continuing to go from strength to strength, a fact made amply clear by our conversation with the Telecom Minister. That Indian telcos will continue to innovate and offer the best services at affordable rates for Indians in every part of nation. 

MAKE IN INDIA: Telecom journey

"I really believe, as Prime Minister said, we need to move from the services paradigm to really the product paradigm.

And that's why we brought in place the PLI scheme (production linked incentive scheme) and it gives incentives for those that produce in India. As part of that, and I'm very glad to report that we've received close to ₹4,305 crores worth of investment, since the telecom PLI has been in place for about a year and a half. It has resulted in ₹85,000 crores worth of incremental sales, of which almost ₹16,500 crores have been exports, and that has resulted in close to creation of 28,000 new jobs.

And so for the first time in India, because of the PLI, you've seen companies like Cisco, Nokia, Ericsson, either manufacturing on their own in India or tying up with an Indian company and producing in India. And that has opened the doors for product innovation to start. On top of that, I have now brought in a new element, introducing an incentive for design-led PLI.

So if you as a firm are not only producing in India, but you are designing your products in India as well, then there is a 1% incentive that has been introduced by the telecom ministry for design-led manufacturing in India. So we don't want only the manufacturing to take place here. We want higher value manufacturing happening here, local value addition happening, as well as the design part being done in India."

– Jyotiraditya Scindia